



dSLRs

The dSLR segment in 2011 was all about changing the perception of dSLRs from being strictly for the serious shooters and professionals to a viable alternative for end-users. Pricing played an important role in bringing the dSLR segment closer to the common man; one can now buy a fairly capable entry-level dSLR for under ₹30,000. Video was a big addition to dSLRs with many entry-level as well as enthusiast models offering full-HD video recording. Vendors like Sony and Nikon also launched compact models to attract buyers who were put off by the bulky bodies of the traditional dSLRs. In a bid to maintain the image quality gap against the micro 4/3rd and compact system cameras, sensors across all dSLR categories went through a refresh, improving on high ISO performance and dynamic range as compared to the previous generation. Similarly, most of the default kit lenses offered by the newer models came with image stabilisation as a default feature, something that's popularly associated with the point-and-shoot segment. Upgrades in the LCD screen size and resolution and standardisation of the live-view mode indicates focus on end-users, as they would find more value in a live-view mode as compared to the hard-core dSLR users who swear by the accuracy of the optical view-finder.

Zero1 Winner

Canon EOS-1D Mark IV

Our test lab reviewed a wide range of dSLRs in 2011 and there was one dSLR that we found



Nikon D7000

Price: ₹74,950 (with AF-S 18-105mm VR Kit Lens)



Nikon D5100

Price: ₹39,950 (with AF-S 18-55mm VR Kit Lens)

hard to fault, the Canon EOS-1D Mark IV. This professional dSLR topped our performance charts, scoring 80 per cent. The 1D Mark IV even managed to go past the more expensive full-frame Nikon D3x dSLR in the low-light tests. The Mark IV has a crop sensor, called APS-H by Canon, that's larger than APS-C. It offers the best of both worlds – better performance in low light than APS-C sensors and higher burst rates than in full-frame models. The camera is built like a tank, has great in-hand feel, tight seams, weather sealing, metal body – the works. With its high-speed shooting, and amazingly clean and detailed output quality of up to ISO 3200, the 1D Mark IV is really meant for action sports shooters or for pros looking to shoot wildlife.

Worthy Mentions

Nikon D7000

The Nikon D7000 came extremely close to the Canon EOS-1D Mark IV in terms of pure image quality performance, although it might not have the build quality or speed of the Mark IV. The high-quality sensor in the Nikon D7000 produced breathtaking images all the way upto ISO 3200, preserving a good amount of detail and keeping the noise at minimal levels. The overall performance of the Nikon D7000 is evidently better than the more expensive Canon EOS 7D and the Canon EOS 60D, enough said. If you're looking for a solid enthusiast's dSLR that will serve you well till you're ready to enter the world of professional digital photography, look no further than the Nikon D7000.

Nikon D5100

The Nikon D5100 is another gem that shows similar characteristics as the Nikon D7000. Scoring very high in the image quality department, the extras in terms of Full HD video recording, fast focusing system and a compact yet rugged body ensure all the ingredients for a perfect entry-level dSLR.

Canon EOS-1D Mark IV

Price: ₹2,59,995 (with kit lens)

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